The acquisition was a lodestar and became a marker of the group, paving the way for India to look beyond its shores to achieve economic progress. It signalled the arrival of Indian companies on the world stage. Ratan was quoted in the *South China Morning Post* as saying, 'It's a momentous occasion where an Indian company has been able to acquire a brand and an overseas company in what potentially is the largest deal of its kind.' Commenting from the business angle, he told *The Globe and Mail*, 'In a world where brand strength is a crucial business success factor, the acquisition of the Tetley brand will provide Tata Tea with a valuable and worthwhile global opportunity.'

'If you look at the tea industry today, apart from a few high-quality grades of Assam tea, almost every other type of producer is losing money. The only people making money are those with strong brands. This is the Tata-Tetley logic,' Krishna Kumar told the *Financial Times*.

Tetley's acquisition also gave the Tatas access into the niche segments of instant, herbal and iced tea. It converted Tata Tea into the world's second-largest tea company with a global presence in over forty countries. Ratan said, 'The Tetley purchase will help Tata expand in Europe, North America and Australia, where it has not been active so far.' Krishna Kumar was of the view that the 'two companies were suited' to each other and in 'two to three years the synergies' would 'produce a global leader'. Tata Tea could also supply several items to Tetley and benefit from its advanced quality systems and tea blending techniques. He told the *Financial Times* that the blending skills would be of particular importance as tea was imported to India.

After the acquisition, Ratan told a leading newsmagazine, 'It is a bold move and I hope that other Indian corporates will follow.' Sure enough, India Inc. did. The deal unleashed the Indian entrepreneurial spirit, riding the waves of the liberalized economy.

The Tetley acquisition also generated great enthusiasm amongst exporters, who saw the acquisition as a landmark step that would strengthen domestic brands for global competition. The chairman of the Indian Tea Association, R.S. Jhawar, told *The Guardian* that the acquisition 'will encourage others to scout for foreign brands'. The Darjeeling Planters Association chairman, Ashok Lohia, said to the same publication, 'Indian firms would [now] be encouraged to think globally.' Even Tetley's prospects brightened significantly due to the merger. Hitherto it had bought